

A Shift in Power

Who cares about Moore's Law anymore? Members of the GigaHertz club are hard pressed to justify an upgrade based on processor speed alone. Gaming you say? Already you can get on your desktop, enough muscle to render the movie *Toy Story* in real-time—a task that took the original creators weeks of hard, painstaking work. What game can do better than movie quality? There will always be some applications to squeeze the last bit of processing power they can get. But are there any for you? The switch from 8 to 16-bit, and 16 to 32-bit happened so quickly, you simply couldn't buy future proof hardware. There are still no takers for the 64-bit Itanium.

Things couldn't be better for the computer industry.

Raw power does not cut it any more. Computers must sell on how well the software they support can serve your needs. After the straight charge to speed, it is now time to refocus on where else computers can go, and what else they can do.

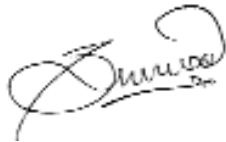
Down this road lies tremendous opportunity. What could you do with a computer that runs solely on ambient light? How about tiny computers with human-size interface devices? How about computers as cheap as ballpoint pens? All of this is happening already. The path to growth is not a straight climb up the charts of processor speeds, but the breadth of variety in applications and availability.

The drive to lower costs for great hardware is clearly successful. The average cost for a decent PC has fallen from Rs 40,000 to near the Rs 20,000 mark. A 'computer for the masses' must cost less than Rs 5,000. We are getting there.

The transition from the mind-set of big, powerful hardware to computers that are 'good enough', go everywhere you need them and do things you want, is an inflection point manufacturers must cross. Those that do, will win big. The recent launch of multiple new low-power processors proves that some companies are sitting up and paying attention.

The confluence of 'good enough' processing with low cost, compact computing in recent times brought us the PDA and the portable MP3 player. It's not risking much to predict the next big thing will not be the launch of a new processor, or a fancy new graphics card—it will be something that brings a new level of convenience at an affordable price point.

In the meanwhile, let us rejoice in the relentless progress of power.



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